THE WEIGHT OF QUIET (voice script)

Written by

Written by

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Draft 10 with ElevenLabs voice direction. [tags] are read by the voice model, not spoken. Parentheticals are for actors and are not read aloud. Edit any tag and it is used on the next recording.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Into the room. The quiet of something that has been going on for hours.

Two mugs on the side table. One steams. The other, further off, is stone cold with a skin on it.

[pointedly] MAYA, 30s, on the sofa, feet tucked under her, wearing his coat. It is too big in the sleeves. Her face is lit blue by her phone. Thumb moving. Scrolling. She has been scrolling for a long time.

JAMES, 30s, in the little kitchen, drying a mug. At home in it.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. Something in him eases. A body that has decided it isn't alone.

[pointedly] Maya scrolls. Looks up at him. Scrolls.

MAYA
(not looking up)
[dry] That's the same mug.

JAMES
[distracted] What?

MAYA
[dry] You've dried that one about... six times.

JAMES
[mildly] It's still wet.

MAYA
[flatly] It's really not.

[pointedly] He keeps drying it. She keeps scrolling. Looks up. Down again.

JAMES
[warmly] There was a heron on the tarn this morning.

MAYA
[bored] Yeah, you said.

JAMES
[pleased] Same spot as yesterday.

MAYA
[sighs] You said that as well. [deadpan] In the car. And at lunch. And in the shop.

JAMES
[stubbornly] It's a good heron.

MAYA
[sarcastic] It's an incredible heron. [short pause] I'm thrilled for it.

[pointedly] Scroll. Look up. He has moved on to wiping a counter that is already clean.

MAYA (CONT'D)
[pointedly] You going to keep doing that?

JAMES
[defensive] Doing what?

MAYA
Whatever... this is.

JAMES
[curtly] I'm tidying.

MAYA
[impatient] It's a holiday let. Someone comes and cleans it on Thursday. That's what we paid for.

JAMES
[muttering] I paid for.

[pointedly] It lands. Small. Petty. He didn't mean it to come out and it came out anyway. She stops scrolling for a second.

MAYA
[scoffs] Wow. [short pause] Okay.

JAMES
[quickly] I didn't mean—

MAYA
[sarcastic] No, you did, and it's fine, [brightly] I'll transfer you.

[pointedly] She holds the phone up, taps something with her thumb, too hard.

JAMES
[sighs] Maya.

MAYA
[clipped] Done. Sorted. We're square.

[pointedly] He puts the cloth down. Comes through. Sits. The armchair, not the sofa. She clocks the distance. Goes back to her phone.

He settles. And then, quiet, barely there, to the empty end of the sofa nearest him, almost a smile:

JAMES
(barely)
[softly] Shove up.

[pointedly] Her thumb stops.

She looks at the empty cushion. Then at him.

MAYA
[quietly] What did you say.

JAMES
[quickly] Nothing.

MAYA
[slowly] You said shove up.

JAMES
[laughs awkwardly] It's just a thing, it's a—

MAYA
[angry] Don't. [short pause] I know what it is. I know EXACTLY what it is.

He rubs his face. Half a second where even he isn't sure. Gone again.

[pointedly] She puts the phone face down on her knee. First time tonight.

MAYA (CONT'D)
[calmly] You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES
[exasperated] Oh, here we go.

MAYA
[controlled] Two. And the second one sweet. Two sugars. [talking fast] You don't take sugar. You have never once taken sugar since I've known you, and you stood there and stirred two sugars into a cup for—

JAMES
[firmly] It's a cup of coffee.

MAYA
[shouting] IT IS NOT A CUP OF COFFEE.

[sharply] It rings off the stone walls. And she hears herself. On the surface it is, exactly, a cup of coffee. That is the thing she can never hold.

MAYA (CONT'D)
[breathing hard] You asked me to come. You did. I didn't invite myself. [mimicking] You said come up for a few days, it'll be good, it'll be quiet.

JAMES
[flatly] It is quiet.

MAYA
[laughs bitterly] It's so quiet, James. It's the quietest place I've ever been.

She stands. Walks, because she can't sit. Picks up one of his jumpers from the back of a chair and folds it without thinking, the way you fold something you've folded a hundred times. Puts it down.

MAYA (CONT'D)
[bitter] Do you know what it's like. Trying to compete with someone who isn't even here. [short pause] I can't win. There's no way to win it. [talking fast] She doesn't get to annoy you. She doesn't get old. She doesn't fold your stuff wrong. [quietly] She just gets to be gone. And perfect. [voice breaking] And I'm the one who's still here.

JAMES
[low voice] Don't.

MAYA
[spiteful] At least if she were alive I could hate her properly.

[quietly] It is out before she can stop it. It is too far. She knows the second it lands.

JAMES
(quiet, and cold)
[coldly] Say that again.

MAYA
[stammering] I didn't—

JAMES
[coldly] Go on. Say it again.

MAYA
[pleading] I didn't mean it. [pause] James. I didn't mean that.

JAMES
[angry] Yes you did. [bitter] You keep a little list, don't you. The sugars. The coffees. Who I look at. [cutting] Like you've got a right to it.

That one finds the exact spot. She goes very still.

MAYA
[quietly] Haven't I?

He doesn't answer.

[slowly] He doesn't answer, and the not answering is the loudest thing in the room.

MAYA (CONT'D)
[quietly] Right.

JAMES
[defensive] That's not what I—

MAYA
[flatly] No, I heard you. I heard you fine.

She crosses to him. Takes his face in both hands. Hard.

MAYA (CONT'D)
[desperate] Look at me. [urgent] Am I here. Am I actually in this room with you or am I just, what, sat on the end of it.

He looks. And for one second he is completely there, and she hates how much she needs that second.

Then his eyes slide. Past her. To nothing. She feels his face turn under her hands toward the empty air.

She lets go like it burned her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
[voice cracking] There. There it is. [laughs bitterly] I've got my hands on your face and you still went.

JAMES
(worn through)
[tired] I know. You've told me. [irritated] You tell me every time.

MAYA
[sharply] Then stop doing it.

JAMES
[angry] You think I'm doing it on purpose? You think I want—

MAYA
[angry] Put it down. Put it down for one night. One. [pleading] And just be here. With me. Like you said you would.

JAMES
[firmly] It isn't—

MAYA
[interrupting] Don't. Don't say it isn't that simple. You could. You choose it. [rising anger] Every single time you choose it over me and then you call it something happening to you.

JAMES
(up, loud)
[shouting] It IS happening to me.

MAYA
[shouting] Then let me in! Once. Let me into the room, just—

JAMES
[frustrated] There's no room—

MAYA
[interrupting] There is always a room. [voice breaking] There is always a room in you and I have never once been let in.

[pointedly] Silence. She is breathing hard. She looks down at the phone still in her hand. Turns it round so he can see the screen.

MAYA (CONT'D)
[breathless] There's a train from Oxenholme at twenty to eight. [quietly] I've been looking at it for an hour.

[pointedly] He looks at the screen. Then at her.

JAMES
[flatly] Then get it.

It is the cruellest thing he has said, and it is said flatly, like he knows she won't. Like she always stays.

MAYA
(barely)
[whispers] You think I won't.

He doesn't answer that either.

[urgent] And then, because he said it, because he can't take it back and can't stand it, he crosses to her. Not to comfort her. To stop the moment existing. He takes her, and it isn't tender, it's a collision. She shoves him in the chest, hard, then grabs a fistful of his shirt and hauls him back in. Teeth. Two people who know each other's bodies better than they know what they are to each other.

For a second it might be enough.

Then she feels it. His breath at her ear, his face turned away. She opens her eyes.

He is looking past her. Over her shoulder. At the room. Holding her, and gone.

She shoves him off.

MAYA
[trembling] You're... even now. Even now, James. [shaky breath] I have got my hands on you and you are still—

She can't finish it. She's shaking.

He is already half-turned back toward the space.

JAMES
(to it, lost)
[quietly] I don't even know if you're—

He can't finish either. He doesn't know who he's asking. He doesn't know if anyone's there.

He drifts to the window and opens it again, without knowing he's done it. The cold comes back in.

MAYA
[frightened] You've opened it again. James. Look at what you're doing.

He doesn't hear her. His hand comes up. Reaching toward the empty air beside him. Palm open. At a height. For a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. His own hand. The two mugs. The cold sweet coffee. The open window. Maya, in his coat. Himself. The empty end of the sofa. The whole shape of it, all at once.

[quietly] His face comes apart.

JAMES
(barely)
[firmly] No.

[sharply] His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug hits the floor and breaks.

MAYA
(small now, frightened)
[quietly] James.

He isn't looking at her. He's looking at the air. He backs away from it, and it comes after him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
(pleading, to no one she can see)
[desperate] Not now. Not tonight.
[pleading] Go on. Please. Go.

MAYA
(barely a whisper)
[whispers] Who are you talking to.

And there it is. The full size of it, finally, in her face.

JAMES
(a roar, torn out of him, at nothing at all)
[screaming] FUCK OFF!

[tense] The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. Back, hard, away from him, across the room, over the broken mug, out through the open window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELLS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing. The gold window shrinking below.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high over the roof. Looks down.

At the small lit cottage. At the one warm window. At the man inside it, tiny now, both hands over his face.

[pointedly] And Maya behind him, still in his coat, her phone lit in her hand. Not going to him. Not leaving either. Watching the man she loves shake at an empty room, a broken cup at his feet, and nothing there. Nothing at all.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look at a place you have just been put out of.

[quietly] The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.